

The Grand Tour: Venetian light

From the late 16th century, young European aristocrats began concluding their education with extended visits to Paris, Venice, Florence and Rome. At its most popular from c.1660–1820, the trip became known as the Grand Tour. With its exceptional quality of light, the city of Venice became particularly fashionable, and by the 1780s, as many as 40,000 tourists travelled there each year to admire the architecture and the art of Bellini, Giorgione, Titian, Veronese and Tiepolo (often considered the greatest Italian Rococo painter whose animated works incorporate many figures and unusual viewpoints, in luminous colours and rich textures). Many tourists took home souvenirs – often large scenic paintings or *vedute* such as those by Canaletto (1697–1768) and Francesco Guardi (1712–93). Canaletto's paintings are characterized by clarity of light, precise perspective, sharp tonal details and glass-like finishes. His fine brushwork created sparkling impressions of the water, skies, architecture and human activity, while Guardi's free handling of paint captured the atmosphere and dazzling effects of light on water.



Canaletto, *The Grand Canal and the Church of the Salute*, 1730